STATE SCAN

RAJASTHAN: DISTRESS OVER BILL *PG 15*

UTTARAKHAND: NIRBHAYA OF THE HILLS *PG 16*





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ARMS DRAWN Assam Congress president Gaurav Gogoi and CM Himanta Biswa Sarma

▶ ASSAM

CROSSING THE BORDER

Political rhetoric tests lines of control in poll-bound Assam as CM Sarma levels dramatic allegations against Gogoi

By **Kaushik Deka**

IT'S A CONFRONTATION THAT IS UNUSUAL in its detail, yet so high in stakes that Assam is hooked. With just a handful of months left for assembly polls, chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma and Assam Congress president Gaurav Gogoi are locked in a war of words. On February 8, in a lengthy press conference, Sarma accused Gogoi and his British wife, Elizabeth Colburn Gogoi, of having links with a Pakistani national and engaging in activities that, he claimed, posed risks to national security. A day later, Gogoi rejected the allegations as a politically motivated fabrication meant to malign him. Already pre-heated from a variety of angles, the electoral rhetoric promises to stay on high flame with this one.

Sarma says his allegations are based on the findings of a Special Investigation Team (SIT) he had constituted on February 17, 2025, after a photograph surfaced showing Gogoi at the Pakistan High Commission in New Delhi, seated next to then high commissioner Abdul Basit. Sarma claims Gogoi had taken around 90 youth to the high commission as part of an effort to "radicalise" them. The SIT submitted its report to Sarma on September 10, 2025.

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At the core of his charges is Gogoi's December 2013 visit to Pakistan—a 10-day trip Sarma describes as a "very confidential" mission, during which he allegedly underwent "some kind of training". The CM questioned why a young politician would travel to what he called "not a tourist country", and why Pakistani authorities altered his visa to allow visits to Islamabad and Karachi. Sarma also cited how despite being active on social media, Gogoi maintained "digital silence" during the trip and never publicly disclosed it.

Sarma asked why Gogoi, as a first-time MP beginning 2014, raised issues such as uranium reserves, border security, submarine capabilities and nuclear plants. Sarma suggested these questions, posed after Gogoi's visit to Pakistan, were raised at Islamabad's behest. (Gogoi, in his third term, is presently his party's deputy leader in the Lok Sabha.) The allegations, Sarma says, go beyond a single trip. He claims Elizabeth worked with the non-profit LEAD Pakistan from 2011 to 2012, and continued to draw money from there after her transfer to LEAD India, in violation of the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act. This,